Rare Orange Baby Sea Turtle Looks Like Pumpkin Spice

From: Popular Science Mined: 2026-10-11 3 min read

In August, a Florida beachgoer spotted a baby **loggerhead** turtle racing toward the ocean. Its shell looked orange-brown, like fall colors. Michael Landress nicknamed it "Pumpkin Spice," even though he says he does not like pumpkin spice drinks.

Most **loggerhead hatchlings** have brown top shells and tan or yellow undersides. Biologist Daniel Evans of the Sea Turtle Conservancy says colors as bold as pumpkin spice are rare.

Color helps **hatchlings hide** in floating **seaweed**. Usual browns blend in. Odd colors stand out more to predators. That is one reason adults usually do not keep such bright hatchling colors.

Loggerheads are named for their big heads. Florida has one of the world's largest nesting groups, but the species is still listed as **endangered** or threatened. Accidental catch in fishing gear is a big danger. This unusual hatchling is a fun reminder that nature can surprise us.

Word Treasure

loggerhead -- A kind of sea turtle with a large head.
hatchlings -- Baby turtles that have just come out of their eggs.
hide -- To stay out of sight so predators are less likely to notice.
seaweed -- Ocean plants that float or grow in the water.
endangered -- At risk of disappearing if not protected.

Background you need

Baby sea turtles crawl from the nest toward the ocean soon after hatching.

Shell colors can help hatchlings hide in floating seaweed.

Some sea turtle species need protection because their numbers are low.

Break it down

WHO: Michael Landress and biologist Daniel Evans
WHAT: A rare orange-colored loggerhead hatchling
WHERE: A Florida beach
WHY: Unusual shell color made the baby turtle stand out

Why it matters

Fun wildlife finds can spark curiosity about animals and why they need protection.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of baby turtle was seen?

- (A) A penguin
- (B) A lizard
- (C) A frog
- (D) A loggerhead

2. Who nicknamed it Pumpkin Spice?

- (A) Michael Landress
- (B) A weather satellite
- (C) A ship captain
- (D) Daniel Evans

3. What does Evans say about unusual colors?

- (A) They only appear in snow
- (B) They are rare
- (C) They mean the turtle can fly
- (D) They are the most common

4. Why does color matter for hatchlings?

- (A) It changes tides
- (B) Camouflage in seaweed
- (C) It teaches math
- (D) It powers rockets

5. What is a hatchling?

- (A) A beach umbrella
- (B) A full-grown whale
- (C) A newly hatched baby
- (D) A type of boat

6. What status do listings give loggerheads?

- (A) Endangered or threatened
- (B) Unprotected toys
- (C) Extinct everywhere
- (D) Only garden pets

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Michael Landress: Named the autumn-colored hatchling Pumpkin Spice.**
2. **Daniel Evans: Explains typical colors and why odd colors are rare.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):